Infixation on the CV Tier: Evidence from Alabama Agent Agreement

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1. The Puzzle

- In the Muskogean language Alabama, agent agreement markers can be realized as a **prefix**, **infix**, or **suffix** depending on the prosodic structure of the stem.
- The **negation** marker also appears to target the same position as the agent agreement affix.

Stem	Root	2SG Form		Gloss
		Positive	Negative	
iCV	*ipa*	is-pa-ti	chi-k-p-o-ti	'you ate'
CVVCV	*choopa*	choo<s>pa-ti	cho<chi-kii>p-o-ti	'you bought'
CVCCV	*hosso*	ho<chi>sso-ti	ho<chi-ki>ss-o-ti	'you wrote'
CVCV	*hompani*	hompan-chi-ti	hompan-chi-k-o-ti	'you played'
-ka	*loska*	los<is>ka-ti	los<chi-k>k-o-ti	'you deceived'
-li	*bitli*	bit-chi-ti	bit-chi-k-o-ti	'you danced'

- Following the general architecture of Kalin (2022), I show that infix placement in Alabama is prosodically conditioned and can be captured in a **Strict CV** framework.

2. Phonological Rules

Sample VI Rules:

1. AGR$_{[2SG,\ AGT]}$ $\longleftrightarrow$ *ch*
2. NEG $\longleftrightarrow$ *k*
3. $\sqrt{\text{BUY}}$ $\longleftrightarrow$ *choopa*

Some Phonological Rules:

1. Complex segments (*ch*) require licensed C positions.
2. Ungoverned V slots trigger *i*-epenthesis.

Pivot Placement:

- ***Prefixing:*** Monosyllabic root.
- ***Suffixing:*** Unfilled final V (e.g. floating final segment in root)
- ***Infixing:*** See below.

3. Infixing Pivot Rules

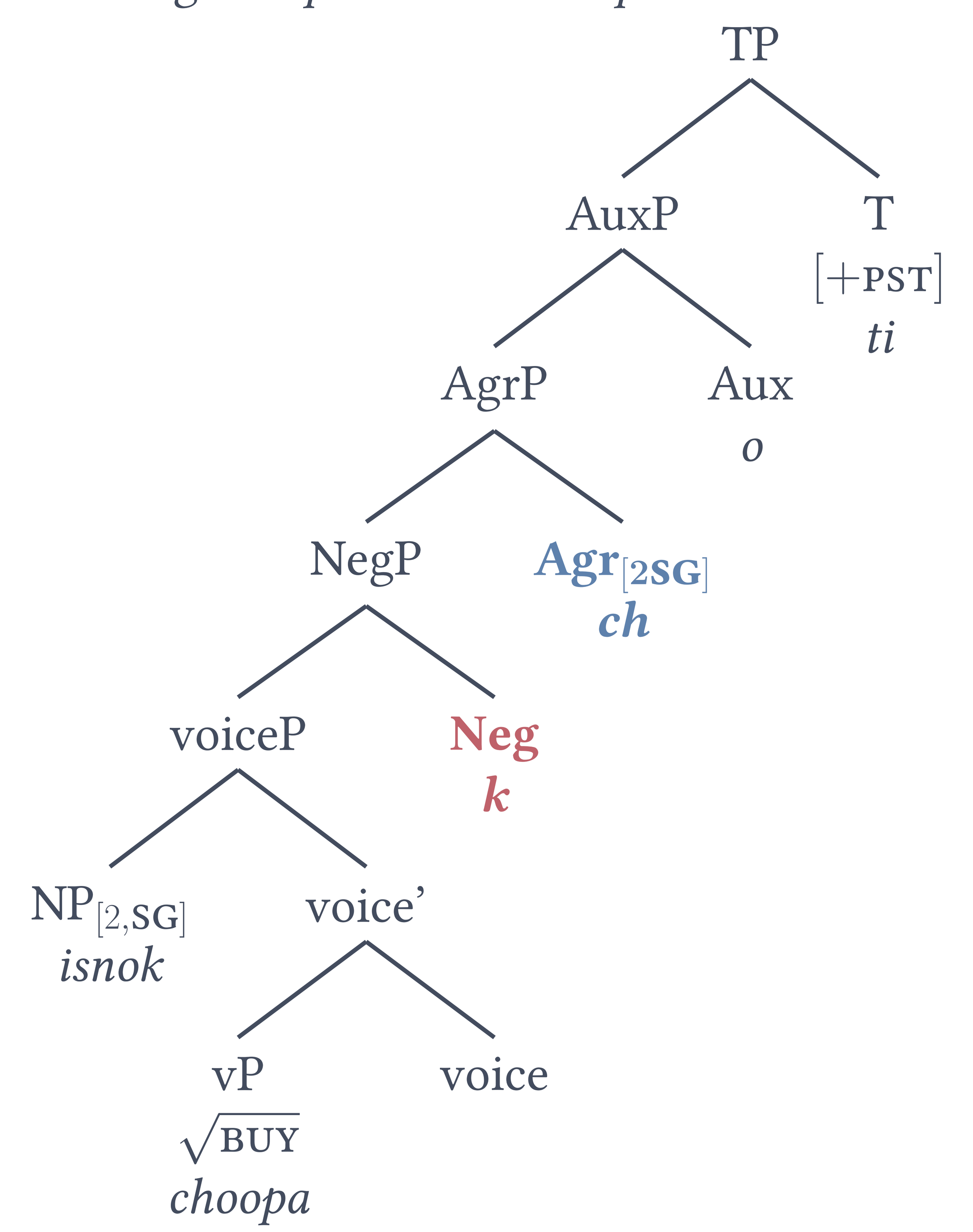
Infixation: If the rightmost C and V are filled, **insert the infix in the middle of the first filled V_iC_{i+1} sequence from the right**. Empty C V segments are ignored in this stage of the derivation.

$$V_i \quad C_{i+1} \quad \cdots \quad C_nV_n \quad \# \quad \rightarrow \quad V_i \quad \langle CV \rangle \quad C_{i+1} \quad \cdots \quad C_nV_n \quad \#$$

- **Negation infix** surfaces to the right of V_i
- **Agent infix** surfaces to the left of C_{i+1}

4. Underlying Structure

Deriving *choopa* → *chochikiipoti*



5. Strict CV Derivation

1. Underlying form *choopa*

$C_1\ V_1\ C_2\ V_2\ C_3\ V_3$

ch o p a

2. Infixation of NEG, right of V_1

$C_1\ V_1\ \langle C_4\ V_4 \rangle\ C_2\ V_2\ C_3\ V_3$

ch o k p a

3. Infixation of 2SG, left of C_4

$C_1\ V_1\ \langle C_5\ V_5 \rangle\ \langle C_4\ V_4 \rangle\ C_2\ V_2\ C_3\ V_3$

ch o ch k p a

4. *i*-insertion: V_5 and V_4 are ungoverned

$C_1\ V_1\ \langle C_5\ V_5 \rangle\ \langle C_4\ V_4 \rangle\ C_2\ V_2\ C_3\ V_3$

ch o ch i k i p a

5. Remaining affixes & surface phonology:

cho<chi-kii>p-o-ti "you didn't buy"

6. Future Directions

→ ***Open Issue:*** This account derives all positive agent agreement, and negative agreement except in 1PL (and a couple more, see handout).

1. *cho<ki-lii>p-o-ti*	'We didn't buy'
2. *cho<chi-kii>p-o-ti*	'You didn't buy'
3. *bit<k-il>k-o-ti*	'We didn't dance'
4. *bit<hili-k>k-o-ti*	'We didn't dance'
5. *bit<chi-k>k-o-ti*	'You didn't dance'

→ ***Key Takeaways/Implications:***

★ Alabama agent agreement supports a bottom-up model of exponence, where infixes are displaced suffixes sensitive to the CV tier.

- The NEG infix and AGT infix target the same position, and align to different C V positions (V vs. C).
- NEG is displaced first, though not in the *closest* stem-internal position that satisfies their pivot/placement.

Selected References

[1] Kalin, L. (2022). *Infixes really are (underlyingly) prefixes/suffixes: Evidence from allomorphy on the fine timing of infixation.* Language, 98(4), 641–682.

[2] Montler, T. R., & Hardy, H. K. (1990). *The phonology of Alabama agent agreement.* WORD, 41(3), 257–276.

[3] Scheer, T. (2004). *A Lateral Theory of Phonology, Volume 1: What is CVCV, and why should it be?*

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